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THE BIG WAVE PM Narendra Modi with senior BJP leaders at the Vijay Sankalp Sabha rally, Hyderabad, July 3

IT WAS AS IF THE **BJP HAD OPENED IMMIGRATION COUNTERS ACROSS THE POLITICAL MAP** AS THE ENTRANTS INCLUDED LEADERS OF EVERY HUE, FROM THE CONGRESS TO NC, TMC AND THE BJD

Rijiju and Sarbanand Sonowal came in when the seas were parting for Modi as he made his strides to Lutyens' Delhi—in 2012, from the Congress and AGP respectively. The other 13 came in the run-up to 2014 or even much after. MSME minister Narayan Rane merged his Maharashtra Swabhiman Paksha with the BJP in October 2019. The prize trophy was of course Jyotiraditya Scindia, who pressed the eject button right from the inner circle of Congress scion Rahul Gandhi in March 2020 and landed in the cockpit as Union civil aviation minister, inheriting the portfolio his father Madhavrao Scindia had held under Narasimha Rao in the 1990s. On July 6, he was also handed the steel ministry.

Proceed outwards from the Centre, along various radials, and look to the states. There are BJP chief ministers who have a long and clear non-BJP past. Most prominently Assam's Himanta Biswa Sarma, who jumped ship from the Congress in 2015 and pretty much opened up the Northeast for the saffron party, becoming a nodal figure in its expansion in the region. In his wake, the trio of Pema Khandu in Arunachal Pradesh, N. Biren Singh in Manipur and Manik Saha drove over from the Congress too, in 2016-17, with practically their state units and governments in the boot. Karnataka's Basavaraj Bommai had come in from another direction, having managed to convert from the socialism of the Janata Dal brand to saffron back in 2008. Lower down the pecking order, the list of politicians of even some repute who have come into the BJP is so huge that we had trouble fitting it into our graphics (*see boxes, split into five regions*).

Immigration counters were virtually open all across the map, and the entrants include everyone from former National Conference No. 2 Davinder Rana in Jammu and Kashmir to former Puducherry PCC chief A. Namassivayam, Mamata Banerjee's one-time lieutenant Suvendu Adhikary in Bengal to Gujarat's stormy petrel Hardik Patel, from second-generation Congressman and ex-Punjab PCC chief Sunil Jakhar to BJD veteran Jay Panda in Odisha to minor Congress royalty like R.P.N. Singh and Jitin Prasada. Typically, the latter finds a place in Yogi Adityanath's present council of ministers, making the same ideological somersault as the voluble ex-Congress spokesperson Rita Bahuguna Joshi did in 2016 to land a place in the Yogi 1.0 council. Below them come the legislators.